Faced with blatant threats to life and property, the individual tea companies adopted their own strategies to deal with the problems. Most of them paid off the militant groups.

Standing Firm

By the time Ratan took over as chairman, the crisis in the tea gardens had become worse. His reputation was at stake and the situation put his skills to test like never before.

The swearing-in of a Congress government under Hiteswar Saikia in June 1991 did not bring peace either to Assam or relief to Tata Tea. Though the new government was not antagonistic towards the group, it was ineffective in curbing the militant activities.

On 8 April 1993, the deputy general manager of Tata Tea's Guwahati office, Bolin Bordoloi, was kidnapped by Bodo militants. The company was served with a ransom demand for $15 million (Rs 54 crore).

Ratan stood firm and refused to yield to the kidnappers' demands. Though he knew that taking such a stance would have its consequences, he was unwilling to relent. He advised Krishna Kumar to negotiate for the release of the employee. Dr Brojen Gogoi, senior welfare officer for the Community Development and Social Welfare wing of Tata Tea, was entrusted with the task.

Gogoi established links with the Bodo group through his erstwhile contacts in the ULFA. With his intervention, after several rounds of parleys, the militants scaled down their demand to Rs 5 lakh, which they claimed were the expenses they had incurred in taking care of Bordoloi while he was in their custody. Ratan, however, did not relent. It was a choice that he was not willing to consider. The negotiations continued and nearly eleven months after he was kidnapped, Bordoloi was released on 2 March 1994. The stand that Ratan took against severe odds had paid off. It came at a price he was happy to pay—he promised more social welfare projects, especially in the remote areas of tea districts.

The Tata Group had already undertaken several social welfare schemes. New programmes would only generate goodwill for them at a time it was most needed. When a company's activities benefit the local population, it automatically pre-empts terrorists from acting against it. The terrorists